

Simple Communication Strategies That Work

Category: Communicate With Confidence

Best for: Adults with hearing loss, hearing aid users, family members, communication partners

Evidence level: Professional, public health, clinical guideline, and peer-reviewed sources

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Why communication strategies matter

Hearing aids and other hearing technologies can be very helpful, but they do not solve every listening problem. Communication strategies are practical ways to make conversation easier. They can help you hear more clearly, reduce listening effort, prevent misunderstandings, and feel more confident asking for what you need.

Strategy 1: Face the person speaking

Seeing the speaker's face can help you understand speech. Helpful phrase: "Could you please face me when you speak? It helps me understand you better."

Strategy 2: Get the speaker's attention before starting

Ask people to say your name first, make sure you are looking, avoid important conversations from another room, and pause until you are ready to listen.

Strategy 3: Move closer to the speaker

Distance makes listening harder. Helpful phrase: "I hear better when I am closer. Could we sit over here?"

Strategy 4: Reduce background noise when possible

Turn off the television during conversation, lower music, close a door or window, move away from kitchen noise, choose quieter tables, and ask people to speak one at a time.

Strategy 5: Ask for rephrasing, not just repetition

Try "Can you say that another way?" or "I missed the last part. Could you rephrase it?"

Strategy 6: Repeat back important information

Repeating back information helps confirm that you understood correctly. Helpful phrase: "Let me repeat that back to make sure I understood."

Strategy 7: Use written support for important details

Use notes, text messages, email summaries, printed instructions, captions, patient portals, meeting agendas, and calendar reminders.

Strategy 8: Plan ahead for difficult listening situations

Before a difficult listening situation, ask where you should sit, who you most need to hear, whether captions or written information are available, and whether a remote microphone would help.

Strategy 9: Be specific about what helps

Instead of saying "I can't hear you," try "Please face me," "Can you slow down a little?" or "Can you send me the address by text?"

Strategy 10: Teach communication partners what helps

Communication is shared. Family, friends, coworkers, and healthcare providers can help by facing you, speaking clearly, reducing background noise, rephrasing, writing down important details, and being patient.

Strategy 11: Use captions and technology when helpful

Helpful tools may include television captions, video call captions, smartphone live caption tools, captioned telephone services, text messaging, hearing aid streaming, remote microphones, TV streamers, and assistive listening systems.

Strategy 12: Use repair phrases instead of pretending

Examples include: "I missed that," "Can you say that another way?" "Can you repeat the number?" "Can you write that down?" and "Can we move somewhere quieter?"

References

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